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The rights to Fyre Festival
sold on eBay for \$245K



Billy McFarland, the fraudster who brought you Fyre Festival, has sold the rights to the brand on [eBay](#) for \$245,300. We do not yet know who the buyer is or what they plan to do with such cursed IP.

Fyre Festival was a downright disaster. What was supposed to be a luxury music festival ended up stranding guests on an island in the Bahamas. Instead of lavish villas and gourmet meals, the festival's clientele, which included wealthy millennial influencers, got flimsy tents and [famously unappetizing](#) cheese sandwiches.

McFarland was later convicted of financial crimes due to his role in the festival, serving about three and a half years before he was released in 2022. But McFarland has not seemed to have learned his lesson. He tried organizing a second Fyre Festival, which was supposed to take place this summer in Mexico with [tickets](#) ranging between \$1,400 and \$1.1 million.

The second Fyre Festival never happened. Playa del Carmen, the Mexican city where McFarland said the festival would take place, claimed that there had not been [any record](#) of planning for the event, which did not have a permit. McFarland [denied](#) this, but [announced](#) a few weeks later that he would sell the Fyre Festival brand.

“Since 2017, FYRE has dominated headlines, documentaries, and conversations as one of the

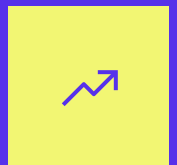
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world’s most talked-about music festivals,”
McFarland [wrote](#), failing to mention that the festival
garnered so much attention due to its colossal
failure. “There is a clear path for operators and
entrepreneurs with strong domain expertise to
build FYRE into a global force in entertainment,
media, fashion, CPG, and more.”

The eBay auction says that a portion of the sale
proceeds will go toward restitution — but McFarland
[owes \\$26 million](#), so this \$245,300 sale isn’t going
to make much of an impact.

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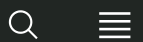


Hulu unexpectedly releases ‘Fyre Fraud’ days before Netflix’s competing documentary

Catherine Shu — 7:22 PM PST · January 14, 2019

Not since the literary biopic showdown between “Capote” and “Infamous” has there been such an

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enlightening context ahead of [co-executive producer Elliot] Tebele’s Netflix documentary.”

“Fyre Fraud” contains exclusive interviews with McFarland, who co-founded Fyre with rapper Ja Rule, and people who used to work for Tebele’s marketing agency FuckJerry, one of the festival’s promoters. Some of Tebele’s former employees

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claim in “Fyre Fraud” that Tebele asked them to cover up early warning signs about the festival.

McFarland was later sentenced to six years to jail for defrauding investors, while Ja Rule is [fighting to be removed as a defendant from a \\$100 million class action lawsuit](#). Attendees paid thousands of dollars for tickets, expecting a luxury music festival in the Bahamas, but instead found themselves staying in tents, no internet service, no water and food like processed cheese sandwiches. Delayed flights [made the experience even more nightmarish](#), as guests were forced to wait hours in the heat for their charter flights back to Miami.

In response, the makers of Netflix’s “Fyre,” directed by Chris Smith (whose “American Movie” won the Grand Jury Prize for Documentary at the Sundance Film Festival in 1999), told Entertainment Weekly that even though they worked with Tebele and Jerry Media (a FuckJerry brand), “at no time did they, or any others we worked with, request favorable coverage in our film, which would be against our ethics. We stand behind our film, believe it is an unbiased and illuminating look at what happened, and look forward to sharing it with audiences around the world.”

Smith [told Entertainment Weekly earlier this week](#) that McFarland wasn’t included in the documentary because he “wanted to get paid” for appearing and “we didn’t feel comfortable with him benefitting after so many people were hurt as a consequence of his actions.”

TechCrunch has contacted Netflix and Hulu for comment.

No newsletters selected.

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Catherine Shu covered startups in Asia and breaking news for TechCrunch. Her reporting has also appeared in the...

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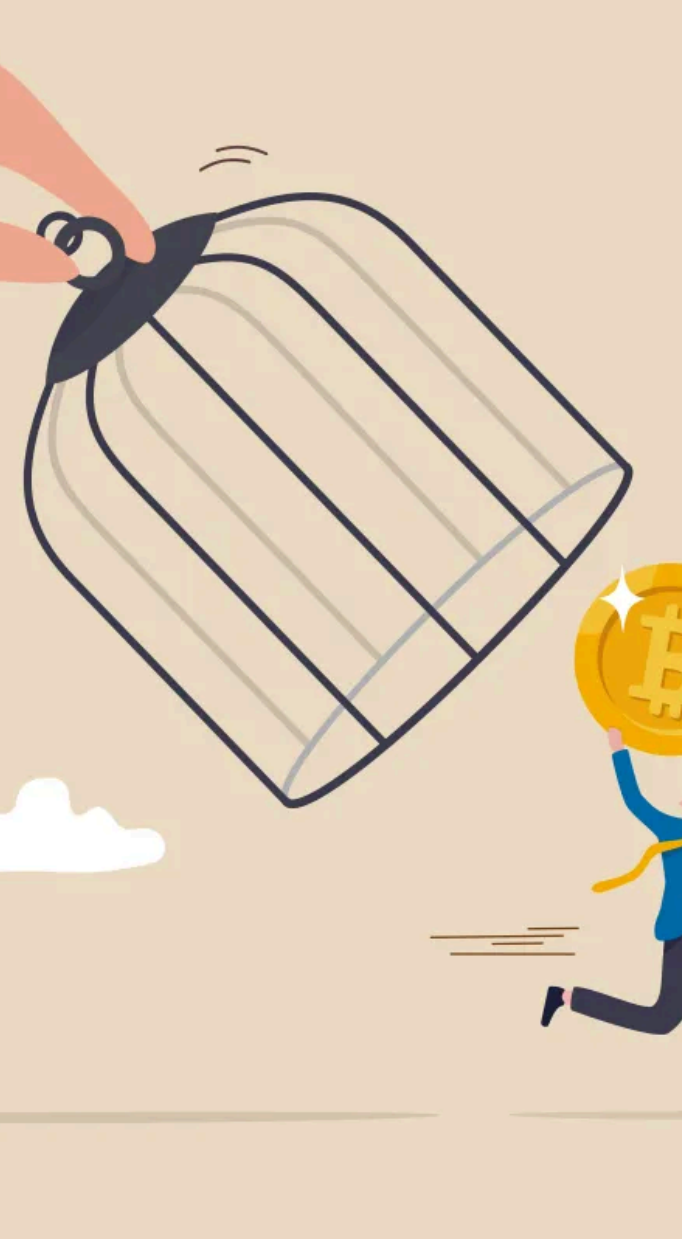


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Of course, Netflix ordered a movie about the big crypto scandal

Amanda Silberling — 11:18 AM PST · February 11, 2022

When news broke earlier this week that the Department of Justice had seized [\\$3.6 billion](#) of allegedly stolen bitcoin, we had some questions. What do these revelations mean about government intervention in crypto? Will this scandal impact the decentralized finance sphere in the long term? Most importantly, which streaming service will order a documentary about the Bonnie and Clyde of bitcoin?

At least one of our questions has been answered: Today, [Netflix announced](#) that it will tell the story of what it calls “the biggest criminal financial crime case in history” with the help of director Chris

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Smith, who brought “FYRE: The Greatest Party That Never Happened” and “Tiger King” to the streaming service. Smith will executive produce alongside Nick Bilton, who produced HBO’s documentary “The Inventor: Out for Blood in Silicon Valley” about the [failure of Theranos](#).

DOJ seizes \$3.6B in bitcoins after busting entrepreneur couple in Bitfinex laundering scheme



The U.S. Justice Department (DOJ) has seized over 94,000 bitcoins that were allegedly stolen in the 2016 hack of crypto exchange Bitfinex and arrested a married couple suspected to have

laundered the money, the department announced today. The couple — Ilya Lichtenstein, 34, and Heather Morgan, 31 — faces charges of conspiring to launder money. [Continue](#)

Like the stories of Elizabeth Holmes and Billy McFarland, Smith and Bilton have a lot to work with here. The alleged criminals, Ilya “Dutch” Lichtenstein and Heather Morgan (who moonlights as the rapper Razzlekhan), were arrested on Tuesday for conspiracy to launder nearly 120,000 bitcoin, which is now worth around \$5 billion. Currently, the husband-wife duo awaits trial, but they were not released on bail because the prosecutor deemed them to be at risk of fleeing. According to [Bloomberg](#), Lichtenstein kept a folder labeled “personas,” and there was a file on his computer called “Passport_ideas” with links to fake passports. The prosecutor added that a plastic bag labeled “burner phones” was found under their bed. You can’t make this stuff up, which is why based-on-a-true-story movies keep Hollywood moving.

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